Max Otto

PhD Candidate · University of Mannheim, GESS

University of Mannheim, A5,6, 68169 Mannheim

max.otto@uni-mannheim.de | www.max-otto.com

I study the interplay of human morality, cooperation, and cultural evolution. Theoretically, I usually approach these questions through (evolutionary) game-theory, both analytically and through computer simulations. Empirically, I am largely tool-agnostic to statistical inference methods, prioritizing design based principles and triangulation through different data types and sources. Methodologically, the lack for high-quality longitudinal data of cultural change, has also led me to more recent work on computational text analysis.

Education

University of Mannheim *Mannheim*

PhD Sociology *Sep 2022 - present*

- Thesis (prelim. title): "Moral culture and evolution in cooperation problems"
- Expected graduation: June 2027

Leipzig University *Leipzig*

M.A. Sociology *Oct 2019 - Aug 2022*

- Elective emphasis: (Micro-)economics and statistics
- Thesis: "Cultural determinants of intergenerational mobility" (Grade: 1.0; in German)

Leipzig University *Leipzig*

(Pure) Mathematics *Oct 2018 - Aug 2019*

- Extracurricular studies (Linear Algebra I,II; Analysis I, II)

Leipzig University *Leipzig*

B.A. Sociology *Oct 2015 - Aug 2018*

- Elective emphasis: Cultural studies
- Thesis: "Transitions of England's labor exchange institutions during late feudalism" (Grade: 1.0; in German)

Professional Experience

2023-	**Graduate Teaching Assistance**, Chair of Sociological Methodology, University of Mannheim
2022-2023	**Research stipend**, Graduate School of Economic and Social Sciences Mannheim
2019-2021	**Graduate Teaching Assistance**, Chair of Sociological Theory, University Leipzig
2018-2019	**Graduate Research Assistant**, Chair of Sociological Theory, University Leipzig

Publications

Peer-reviewed journal articles

Otto, M. 2026. *The cultural foundations of cooperation enforcement*. Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization, 244, 107494. `https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jebo.2026.107494`

- Awarded CDSS publication of the year 2026

Under Review

Otto, M. 2026. *Context-Adaptive Dictionary Analysis: Tracing Constructs in Historical Texts under Semantic Change.* Revise & Resubmit at *Behavior Research Methods*

In Progress

Otto, M. *Retaliatory honor catalyzes the expansion of the moral circle.*

Otto, M. *Mapping Trajectories of Universal Morality: Computational Evidence from 200 Years of American Newspaper Coverage.*

Awards, Fellowships, & Grants

2026	**CDSS Publication of the Year**, Center for Doctoral Studies in Social and Behavioral Sciences	*1,000€*
2026	**Completion stipend**, Graduate School of Economic and Social Sciences, Mannheim	*9,000€*
2022	**PhD research stipend**, Graduate School of Economic and Social Sciences, Mannheim	*∼33,000€*
2014	**DPG Abitur Award**, German Physical Society	

Presentations

Contributed Presentations

Otto, M. 2024. Evolutionary dynamics of moral beliefs. Venice International University, Italy.

Otto, M. 2024.Cultures of reciprocity, revenge, and reputation. The role of beliefs and preferences in the enforcement of cooperation. International Network of Analytical Sociology, Leipzig University, Germany.

Otto, M., 2023.Culture and the Mechanisms of Cooperation: The Interplay of Group Identity and Retaliatory Honor in Social and Economic Exchange. Analytical Sociology: Theory and Empirical Applications, Venice International University, Italy.

Teaching Experience

Research design *Mannheim*
Tutorial – Graduate level *2025-27*
- Inference techniques: (Survey-)Experiments, Matching, DiD, IV, RDD
- Application over exemplary data in R

Multivariate data analysis *Mannheim*
Exercise – Undergraduate level *2023-26*
- Linear Regression, Logistic/Probit Regression, Theory Testing
- Application over exemplary data in Stata

Data analysis *Mannheim*
Exercise – Undergraduate level *2024-26*
- Descriptive Statistics, Probability Theory, Hypothesis Testing
- Application over exemplary data in Stata

Sociological Theory *Leipzig*
Tutorial – Undergraduate level *2020-21*
- Review of main theoretical programs in sociology with an emphasis on contemporary schools of thought.
- Introduction to formal modeling, rational-choice and game-theoretic frameworks in sociology

Introduction to Scientific Research *Leipzig*

Tutorial – Undergraduate level *2019-20*

- Introduction to fundamental concepts of sociological theory and the construction of hypotheses.
- Introduction to tools for scientific work (literature research tools, bibliography management etc.).

Skills

Empirical	**Econometrics, Causal Inference (IV, DiD, RDD), Text-as-Data (NLP)**,
Programming	**R**, Advanced
	Python, Stata, Proficient
	Matlab, Intermediate
Computing	**HPC Clusters (Slurm), Bash/Unix Shell, Git**, Intermediate
Research	**LaTeX, RMarkdown, Reproducible Workflow**, Advanced
Languages	**German**, native
	English, C1/C2 — Toefl 115/120